The opposing lines at Lepanto
This painting, completed in 1581, gives a spectacular aerial view of the battle. It depicts three Christian squadrons (left) firing on the smaller galleys of the Ottoman fleet (right).

THE BATTLE OF LEPANTO

On September 16, 1571, a large Christian fleet set sail from Sicily on an expedition to relieve Venetian-owned Cyprus, then under attack by the Ottoman Empire. Most of the men and galleys had been supplied by Venice and Habsburg Spain, but Genoa, the Papacy, Savoy, and Malta's Knights of St. John had all made contributions. In command was the Habsburg prince Don John of Austria.

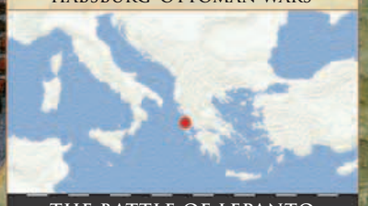
As his fleet drew near to where the Ottomans lay at Lepanto in western Greece, Don John organized the galleys into four squadrons: that on the right commanded by Genoese Giovanni Andrea Doria, the left under Venetian Agostino Barbarigo, the center under Don John himself. Spanish admiral Santa Cruz was placed in reserve.

Facing the Christian fleet, the Ottoman forces advanced in a crescent, with the admiral Ali Pasha in the center, the right wing under Suluc Mehmed Pasha, and the left under the feared corsair Uluç Ali, an Italian-born convert to Islam. As the moment for combat approached Don John had the Holy League's banner of Christ crucified raised above his flagship, *Real*. Ali Pasha sailed under a banner embroidered 29,800 times with the name of Allah.

CANNON AND ARQUEBUS

The Christians placed their faith in firepower. Most of their galleys had a centerline cannon or culverin in the bows firing up to a 60 lb (25 kg) iron shot, flanked by up to four smaller cannon, plus many swivel guns and soldiers with arquebuses. The Ottoman galleys were smaller than the Spanish ones, but similar to the Venetian. They had fewer and less powerful cannon and their soldiers depended more on composite bows than on firearms. The Ottomans hoped to maneuver, ram, and board the Christian vessels. Both sides hoped to maintain formation and avoid being attacked on the flank.

HABSBURG–OTTOMAN WARS



THE BATTLE OF LEPANTO

Date	October 7, 1571
Location	Gulf of Patras, off western Greece
Result	Victory for the Holy League

COMBATANTS

HOLY LEAGUE: SPAIN **VENETIAN REPUBLIC** **PAPAL STATES** **REPUBLIC OF GENOA** **SAVOY** **KNIGHTS OF MALTA**	**OTTOMAN EMPIRE**

COMMANDERS

Don John of Austria	**Muezzinzade Ali Pasha**

FORCES

Ships: 206 galleys, 6 galleasses	**Ships:** 230 galleys

LOSSES

Men: 8,000 casualties **Ships:** 13 galleys sunk	**Men:** 20,000 casualties, **Ships:** 50 galleys sunk, 130 captured



1547–1578

DON JOHN OF AUSTRIA

COMMANDER OF SPAIN'S MEDITERRANEAN GALLEY FLEET

The illegitimate half-brother of Philip II of Spain, John of Austria was named commander of the Spanish galley fleet at the age of 18, with more experienced admirals to advise him. He developed a reputation for reckless courage during the suppression of the Moriscos revolt in Andalusia, before his appointment to lead the fleet of the Holy League. Victory at Lepanto was followed by the capture of Tunis from the Muslims in 1573. Philip then sent him to deal with a rebellion in Flanders, where he died aged 31.